Project Timeline:

Fall 2025-Spring 2026

Keywords: - Toy Design – Children's Product Design - Roleplay – Imaginative/Pretend Play

Consideration:

Inclusivity (sensory, user accessibility, etc.)

Safety guidelines for children's product (ASTM – American Society for Testing and Materials)

User behavior

Visual

Children ergonomics

Project Blurb

For my senior BFA design project, I am developing a **modular pretend playset for children ages 3–5**. The playset is designed to transform into different settings to encourage imagination and storytelling, while incorporating principles of **ergonomics, and gender neutrality**. My goal is to create a flexible, open-ended play environment that supports children's **social, emotional, cognitive, and physical development**.

Research

Play Theory

Source (APA):

Saracho, Olivia N., and Bernard Spodek. "CHILDREN'S PLAY AND EARLY CHILDHOOD EDUCATION: INSIGHTS FROM HISTORY AND THEORY." *The Journal of Education*, vol. 177, no. 3, 1995, pp. 129–48. *JSTOR*, http://www.jstor.org/stable/42742374.

Metacommunicative Theory (Bateson, 1955)

- Suggests children participating in make-believe play inform their peers that the incidents are imitations of reality, not reality itself
- By play, children learn to function concurrently on two levels:
    - 1. Make believe purposes of objects and actions
    - 2. Authenticity of life (actual identities of players and actual purpose of objects and actions
- Bateson also contends that play texts and experiences are perpetually contrived in relation to their contexts – the play environment.
    - Play is the metacommunicative context to the text of reality that provides to the cultural and personal likeness of the individual
    - Theory suggests that play and fantasy serve important functions in children's cognitive development.

Arousal Seeking / Modulation Theory

- Developed by Berlyne
- Suggests that a need or drive to keep arousal at an optimal level exists in a child's central nervous system
- Play allows the organism to search for sources of arousal that provides specific information / stimulation
- Excess stimulation (appearance of a strange object) raises arousal to disturbingly high level
    - Leads to children to participate in activities that decrease stimulation (ie. Examine objects to gain familiarity with them)
    - In contrast, insufficient stimulation causes drop in arousal levels, leading to boredom
        - Individual then seeks activities to raise stimulation --> search for activities is referred to as diverse exploration

Second Arousal Seeking Theory

- Proposed in 1973 by Ellis
- Play is a stimulus seeking activity that provides children with opportunities to manipulate objects and actions in new ways
- Believed that play raises both stimulation and arousal levels
- People constantly strive for sensory variation
    - If sensory input remains constant, individuals will not pay attention to it for long
    - Will in result search for additional sources of information in order to gain adequate stimulation
    - Too much available information will cause individuals to avoid stimulation by not attending to some of the sources
- Proposes that individuals think best in situations that provide an optimal degree of novelty, uncertainty, and complexity --> play allows for children to achieve this optimal level, helps children regulate stimulation as it is under their control

Three Stages of Play

- Established by Piaget

Sensori-motor

a. Repetitive actions focus on physical activity
b. Free exploration but accomodation occurs due to various properties possessed by the objects the child uses

Symbolic

c. Make believe / symbolic play evolves
d. Symbolic ability make it possible for a child to pretend – create stories and act them out
e. Doesn't require the presence of actual objects that are being represented
f. Begins when children are 18 months, continues until they are 7 years old
g. By 7 years, children no longer engage in dramatic play, engage more in generating fictional stories that are written down rather than played out.

Games with rules

h. Based on social conventions and interactions
i. Develops during Piaget's concrete operational stage of development (begins at age 6-7 years)

j. Requires particapation of two or more children
k. Game examples: Checkers, chess, card games
l. As rule games are established, sensorimotor play and symbolic play (dramatic play form) diminish

- Stages represent types of play which develop in a sequential order and the mental structure found in one stage are integrated into later stages as the child grows
- Piaget thought that changes in cognitive development provide basis for changes in play
- Particular types of play requires a certain level of cognitive sophistication
- Suggested that play does not further cognitive development, reflects the level of cognitive development that has been obtained

Lev S, Vygotsky (1896 – 1934)

- Russian psychologist, did not view play as simply a product of cognitive development, but rather a tool that support this development
- Claimed that symbolic and dramatic play promotes children's abstract thinking
    - Helps them interpret the objects they are representing in their dramatic play
- When play first starts, around 18 months, materials used in play must have similarities to what they stand for
- Later, children become more flexible in deciding to how they use materials and what they mean
- Described play as children's make believe events that are based on real life anxieties

Pioneers of Educational Play

Friedrich Froebel

- Established the kindergarten, using play as a medium for education through manipulative materials called Gifts.
- Maria Montessori developed her method by observing children's natural play and systematizing it into structured activities
- John Dewey rejected Froebel's views, advocating for play as a means for children to reconstruct their experiences and learn from them.

Educational Implications of Theories of Play

- Activities in dramatic play often reflect the activities adults engage in within the community

- Teachers provide dramatic play or puppet play opportunities because they think these might help children to work out conflicts in their feelings and relationships
    - Feelings are often thought to be interpreted through play
- Arousal seeking theory has provided early childhood teachers with justification for using child initiated play activities
- Suggests that children themselves must be relied upon to judge the amount of stimulation that should be provided to them in the classroom
- When they are understimulated, they will seek activities of play to increase sensory arousal, when overstimulated, they will avoid such situations
- Metacommunicative theory of play is often used by teachers to understand play discourse
- Teachers use Piagetian theory and judgement of developmental appropriateness to integrate dramatic play in preschools and kindergarten

Pretend Play in Childhood: An Integrative

The Role of Play and Make Believe in Children's Cognitive Development: Implications for Social Class Differences and Education

Barnett, Mark A. "The Role of Play and Make-Believe in Children's Cognitive Development: Implications for Social Class Differences and Education." *The Journal of Education* 159, no. 4 (1977): 38–48. http://www.jstor.org/stable/42773976.

- Singer's (1966, 1973) extensive studies of imaginative play in children indicate that the ability to organize and integrate diverse stimuli
    - Studies by Paivivo (1970), Reese (1970), and Rohwer(1970) indicates that imaginery play may have a significant role in the early learning processes of children.

Play and Creativity in Children

- Among the various definitions of creativity, there is a common theme in these definitions --> emphasis on unrestrained and divergent thought processes
    - Within this framework, the development of creative thought processes would appear to be one aspect of the child's cognitive functioning intimately linked with early play and make believe experiences. (41)
- Dansky and Silverman (1973) reported that the opportunity for preschoolers to engage in playful activitiy with a set of objects results in an increase in alternative uses for those objects, as measured by Torrance's *Unusual Uses* Creativity task
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Social Pretend Play in Toddlers: Parallels with Social Play and with Solitary Pretend

Howes, Carollee, Olivia Unger, and Laura Beizer Seidner. "Social Pretend Play in Toddlers: Parallels with Social Play and with Solitary Pretend." *Child Development* 60, no. 1 (1989): 77–84. https://doi.org/10.2307/1131073.

Overview of Study

- The study investigates **social pretend play** in toddlers, focusing on how it parallels **social play** and **solitary pretend play**.
- Conducted by Carollee Howes, Olivia Unger, and Laura Beizer Seidner at UCLA, involving **42 toddlers** aged **14 to 38 months**.
- Children were observed during **two 15-minute sessions**: one alone and one with a peer, using a set of toys.
- Findings suggest that social pretend play forms emerge **later** than solitary and social play forms.

Developmental Stages of Play

- The progression of **social pretend play** is outlined through a **sequence of levels** based on children's ages:
    - **Level I (12-15 months)**: Parallel play with eye contact and social exchanges.
    - **Level II (15-20 months)**: Similar pretend acts with turn-taking and eye contact.
    - **Level III (20-24 months)**: Social exchanges where partners reverse each other's actions.
    - **Level IV (24-30 months)**: Joint activities with a common plan but no integration of actions.
    - **Level V (30-36 months)**: Differentiation of leader and follower roles in pretend activities.
- The study parallels these levels with the emergence of **solitary pretend play** as well, suggesting a developmental lag in social pretend play.

Cognitive and Social Development

- **Social pretend play** requires children to manage symbolic transformations and communicate them, integrating **cognitive** and **social development**.
- Initial attempts at sharing pretense may be enhanced by **parental interaction** but are limited by toddlers' cognitive and linguistic abilities.
- The study highlights the complexity of joint pretend play, suggesting that cognitive and linguistic skills are crucial for successful interaction in social pretend play.

Methodology of the Study

- Subjects included **22 girls and 20 boys** across various age intervals, all from well-educated families in an urban area.
- Each child participated in **two videotaped sessions**: one alone and one with a peer, both conducted in their homes within a week.
- Toys used for play were selected to encourage pretend and social interaction, provided in duplicate to facilitate engagement.
- The sessions were designed to analyze the developmental sequence of social pretend play in relation to social and solitary play.

Results of Pretend Play Analysis

- All children engaged in pretend play alone and social play when paired with a peer.
- Social pretend play was observed in **19 out of 21 dyads**; types of activities are detailed in Table 2.
- The complexity of play episodes varied primarily in the quality of social interactions and integration between peers.
- No sex differences were found in types of pretend activities; more complex play episodes (Levels IV and V) typically lasted longer than simpler ones (30+ seconds vs. 6-29 seconds).
- Level II social pretend episodes were generally the briefest, lasting 5 seconds or less.

Age and Complexity of Play

- Age ranges for observed levels of solitary and social pretend play were outlined in Table 3.
- For each level of play, age ranges were defined, with the majority (67%) included in parentheses.
- Preliminary analyses indicated no significant differences in the number of episodes between girl, boy, and mixed-gender dyads, allowing for data combination across genders.
- Younger children displayed less complex play, while older children showed an increased repertoire of complex pretend play as they aged.
- The proposed sequence of social pretend play was tested using Green's index of consistency (I), resulting in a value of .85, indicating a scalable progression in play complexity.

Source Pages: [6, 7]

Discussion of Findings

- The study confirmed the scalable sequence of social pretend play, demonstrating that children matched pretend acts with partners before coordinating social bids and parallel pretend acts.
- Nearly all dyads produced profiles that fit the proposed developmental sequence, indicating structured evolution from solitary to social pretend play.
- Caution is advised when interpreting results due to the cross-sectional nature of the study; longitudinal research is needed for validation.
- Differences were noted in the engagement levels of solitary vs. social pretend play, particularly at Level V, where social pretend was observed more frequently than solitary play.
- Familiarity between children may enhance their ability to assume roles and coordinate shared meanings during play.

Source Pages: [8, 9]

Table 1

Successive Levels of Social Play and of Social Pretend Play, and Age Ranges Proposed as Characteristics of Their Emergence

Social Play	Social Pretend Play
I. 12-15 months	
1. 12-15 months: - Parallel play with eye contact, and/or exchanges of a social behavior	- Pretend acts preformed proximally and in eye contact with peer elicilt no response (A feeds self, B ignores)
II. 15 – 20 months	
- Engagement in similar activities is accompanied with turn-taking social exchanges (while digging in sandbox, A smiles to B and B vocalizes back)	- Performance of similar/identical pretend acts accompanied by eye contact (both push dolls in carriages)
II. 20 – 24 months	
- Social exchange is marked by each partner taking turns at reversing the actions of the other (run-chase game, roll back and forth)	- Engagement in similar pretend activities is accompanied by social exchanges (pushing dolls in carriages: A smiles at B, B offers doll to A)
IV. 24 – 30 months	
- The joint activity has a common plan and the pair's actions are integrated (conversation during joint building of a block structure shows that both intend it for trucks to drive under)	- Each participant's pretend reflects the same theme but their actions show no within-pair integration (playing "tea party", both pour "tea", add "sugar", and "drink" with smiles and talking)
V. 30-36 months	
- The social play activity shows differentiation of leader and follower roles (while jointly building and block structure, A directs building construction and B delivers the blocks)	- The joint pretend activity involves enactment of complementary roles such as mother-baby or doctor-patient (A sets table, tells B where to sit, pours them "tea," and "feeds" them; B emits baby-like cries and says "more tea")

Age Ranges at Which the Given Level of Complexity Was Observed For Each Type of Play

	Solitary Pretend		Social Play		Social Pretend	
Level & Expected Age	n	Age Range	n	Age Range	n	Age Range
12-15: 67%	41	14 - 38 (14 - 16)	20	14 – 38 (14 - 16)	19	14 - 38 (14 - 16)
15-20: 67%	33	16 – 38 (20 - 22)	14	16 – 38 (17 - 19)	12	16 - 38(*)
20-24: 67%	31	20-38 (23-25)	12	20 – 38 (20 - 22)	11	20 – 38 (23 - 25)
30-36: 67%	21	22-38 (23-25)	10	24 – 38 (26 - 28)	8	25 – 38 (26 - 38)
All 67%	2	34-38	10	29 – 38 (29 - 38)	5	29 – 38 (29 - 33)

Understanding Pretend Play

Child Development Institute. _Understanding Pretend Play: When a Child Pretends_. Sarah Lawrence College, 1987.

Pretend Play Definition: Pretend play begins around age two, where children imaginatively transform objects and create scenarios.

Examples of Pretend Play:

A child feeding a baby doll or setting the table reflects daily life actions.

A child creating a car accident scenario while playing with toy vehicles demonstrates storytelling through actions.

Role of Adults: Adults should be responsive play partners, following the child's lead without imposing themes or materials.

Social Interaction in Play: Collaborating with peers during pretend play helps children develop negotiation skills, share experiences, and find solutions to conflicts.

Solo Play Importance: Independent play allows children to explore their imagination without the need for negotiation, although excessive repetition may indicate a need for more peer interaction.

Sources of Pretend Play Ideas

Observational Learning: Children draw from experiences at home, school, and their neighborhoods to create play scenarios.

Cultural Influence: Diverse family backgrounds and cultural groups influence the themes children explore in their play.

Media Influence: Children adapt characters and stories from books, TV shows, and films, but excessive media consumption can inhibit creativity.

Inner Conflicts and Fantasies: Children may act out situations based on their feelings or experiences, turning real-life conflicts into imaginative narratives.

Role of Adults: Adults should provide limits on play themes to ensure safety and encourage a balance between imaginative exploration and realistic boundaries.

Play Environments and Materials

Variety of Spaces: Pretend play can happen anywhere; children are resourceful in transforming ordinary spaces into imaginative worlds.

Materials for Play:

Realistic props (toys, kitchen sets) can enhance play, but discarded household items can also serve as effective materials.

Encourage creativity by providing open-ended materials (e.g., fabric, boxes) that require imagination for transformation.

Accessibility of Materials: Play materials should be easily reachable and organized so children can initiate their own play.

Encouraging Miniature World Play:

Provide clear spaces for building and enacting dramas.

Offer various small items (buttons, pebbles) to inspire creativity.

Importance of Adult Presence: Adults nearby can enhance the child's sense of play value and provide assistance if needed without dominating play.

Importance of Pretend Play

Learning Through Play: When children engage in pretend play, they learn by exploring materials, developing narratives, and solving problems without direct instruction.

Social and Intellectual Development:

Dramatic play fosters understanding of social roles and enhances communication and collaboration skills.

Activities like building a zoo allow children to practice physical principles, aesthetics, and language skills.

Narrative Construction: Pretend play enables children to construct stories, which is essential for memory, communication, and understanding experiences.

Intellectual Engagement: Children are involved in significant cognitive work, preparing them for future academic learning in literacy and scientific thinking.

Long-term Benefits: Pretend play continues to evolve as children grow, laying the foundation for literacy, creativity, and social knowledge.

Encouraging Pretend Play

Materials to Provide:

For dramatic play: clothes for dress-up, kitchen items, doctor’s kits.

For miniature play: construction materials, figures, and small objects.

Play Spaces: Designate areas in homes and schools for different types of play to facilitate engagement and creativity.

Facilitating Peer Interaction: Adults can suggest new play partners but should step back during play to allow children to lead.

Supporting Child-Led Play: When adults engage, they should follow the child's direction, providing encouragement rather than enforcing themes.

Overview of Pretend Play

Citations: Fein, Greta G. "Pretend Play in Childhood: An Integrative Review." *Child Development*, vol. 52, no. 4, 1981, pp. 1095–118. *JSTOR*, https://doi.org/10.2307/1129497. Accessed 22 Oct. 2025.

Pretend play is a significant area of study in child development, reflecting various theoretical perspectives and developmental changes.

Definition and Nature of Pretend Play

Pretend play is defined as behavior performed in a simulative, nonliteral mode.

- Various terms like imaginative play, make-believe play, and fantasy play are used interchangeably.
- Criteria for identifying pretend play include absence of necessary materials, nontraditional outcomes, treating inanimate objects as animate, and substituting objects.
- The ability to recognize pretend play relies on contrasting it with real-life behaviors.

Historical Context of Pretend Play Studies

The study of pretend play has experienced three significant revivals.

- The first wave (1920s-1930s) relied on anecdotal accounts and lacked empirical research.
- The second wave (1940s-1950s) focused on behaviorally oriented personality theories, viewing pretend play as a projective test.
- The third wave (1970s) was influenced by Piaget and emphasized systematic studies of pretend play, particularly in early childhood.

Developmental Changes in Pretend Play

Pretend play evolves through distinct stages from infancy to school age.

- Piaget proposed an inverted U-shaped curve for pretend play, peaking between ages 1 and 6.
- Pretend play begins around 12-13 months, with a significant increase in prevalence and frequency until about 30 months.

- By kindergarten, pretend play comprises approximately 33% of play activities, but remains lower compared to other forms.

Components and Characteristics of Pretend Play

Pretend play consists of various components that develop over time.

- Self-referenced behavior is common in early pretend play, transitioning to other-referenced behavior by 15-21 months.
- The ability to use substitute objects increases significantly between 19 and 24 months, with 75% of children demonstrating this behavior by 24 months.
- By age 4, children often create imaginary companions, with estimates of prevalence ranging from 12% to 65%.

Sociodramatic Play and Social Interaction

Sociodramatic play involves collective symbolism and role enactment among peers.

- A shift from solitary to social pretense is suggested to occur around age 3.
- Metacommunications about play increase with age, with children understanding indirect implications of the word "pretend" by age 4.
- Role enactment in sociodramatic play reflects reciprocal social relationships and becomes more complex as children develop.

Development and Features of Role Play

Role play in children varies significantly based on observational methods and age, with notable increases in engagement as children grow.

- Estimates of role play prevalence vary: less than 1% in brief observations, approximately 8% in continuous observations, and up to 25% when measuring time spent in role play.
- No significant changes in role play frequency between ages 3 and 5 in some studies, while others show increases in time spent in role play.
- Relationship roles are most common, with 3-year-olds engaging in self-referenced roles and 5-year-olds incorporating observed relationships.
- Older children exhibit more diverse role-related activities and better tolerate deviations from role-appropriate behavior.

Behavioral Correlates of Sociodramatic Play

Sociodramatic play is linked to positive emotional and social behaviors, enhancing children's social skills and interactions.

- Engaging in sociodramatic play is associated with positive emotionality, joy, persistence, and concentration.
- Children in this play are more likely to share, communicate, and receive positive reinforcement from peers.
- Hostility in play is infrequent and typically occurs in a pretend context, with both prosocial and negative pretense positively correlated.
- The correlation between play and positive social behavior is unclear, as it may reflect inherent child characteristics or be necessary for play.

Relation Between Play, Language, and Cognition

The relationship between pretend play and cognitive development is complex, with studies showing varying correlations with language skills.

- Piaget's theory suggests pretend play marks the beginning of representational thinking, but studies show mixed results regarding its correlation with language.
- Some studies indicate that symbolic play and language development occur together, but correlations diminish when age is controlled.
- Object permanence is linked to symbolic play, but only 50% of children show synchrony between play and object permanence levels.
- No convincing evidence establishes pretend play as a prerequisite, concurrent achievement, or consequence of cognitive abilities.

Individual Differences in Pretend Play

Individual differences in pretend play reflect stable traits influenced by child-rearing practices and can be modified through training.

- Pretend play may indicate a general tendency to use imagination in coping with real-life events.
- Children who engage in imaginative play often display advanced social skills, cooperation, and friendliness with peers.
- Studies show a correlation between pretend play and creativity, although evidence linking them as dispositional variables is limited.
- Pretend play may reflect a flexible disposition applicable in various social and non-social situations.

Sex Differences in Play Preferences

Sex differences in play preferences are evident, with girls favoring dolls and boys preferring blocks and transportation toys.

- Girls engage in doll and house play earlier (18 months) than boys with trucks (30 months).
- Sex typing in play occurs earlier for girls with dolls than for boys with transportation toys.
- Boys are more likely to adopt fantastic roles, while girls prefer domestic roles in their play.
- Discrepancies exist in studies regarding overall levels of pretend play between boys and girls, influenced by environmental factors.

Social Class Effects on Pretend Play

Social class influences on pretend play are often confounded with cultural factors, making it difficult to draw clear conclusions.

- Studies suggest poor children may engage less in pretend play, but findings are inconsistent and often reflect setting factors.
- Observational studies show no significant differences in the onset of pretend play across social classes.
- Variance within social class groups may be as significant as between-group differences, indicating the need for further research.

Child-Rearing Factors Influencing Play

Child-rearing practices significantly impact children's engagement in pretend play, with parents often reinforcing or discouraging certain behaviors.

- Parents may not actively model pretend play, as it is often initiated by children themselves.
- Secure attachment to parents is linked to higher levels of pretend play.
- Children from supportive environments with engaged parents are more likely to engage in imaginative play.
- High levels of parental punishment or marital discord correlate with lower levels of imaginative play.

Training Studies to Enhance Pretend Play

Training studies have shown that sociodramatic play can be enhanced through adult interaction and specific behavioral techniques.

- Successful training involves active adult participation and appropriate themes for sociodramatic play.

- Toys alone or extra playtime do not enhance pretend play; structured adult involvement is crucial.
- Positive effects can be observed in both lower-class and middle-class children, raising questions about initial social class differences.
- The durability of training effects and their generalization across settings remain areas for further investigation.

Conditions Affecting Pretend Play

Pretend play is influenced by situational, motivational, and emotional factors, which can either facilitate or inhibit engagement.

- The immediate environment's similarity to real life can impact the quality of play, with realistic props facilitating engagement.
- Novelty can initially enhance play but may lead to boredom over time, reducing exploratory behavior.
- Emotional factors, such as stress and anxiety, can suppress play, although some studies suggest a modest relation between stress and play content.
- Environmental design, including play space features, may encourage specific types of play, warranting further exploration.

Functions and Consequences of Pretend Play

Pretend play contributes to children's development, potentially fostering imaginative thinking and social skills, though long-term outcomes are less understood.

- Research paradigms include examining short-term effects of play opportunities, longitudinal assessments, and training interventions.
- Pretend play is associated with creativity and combinational flexibility, enhancing problem-solving abilities.
- Role-playing may improve perspective-taking and reduce egocentricity, although the sustainability of these effects is uncertain.
- The cathartic function of play has not been strongly supported, with little evidence that aggressive play reduces real-life aggression.

The Role of Play in Child Development

Play is a crucial aspect of child development that influences various cognitive and social skills.

- Play facilitates the development of imagination and creativity in children.
- It serves as a medium for children to explore their environment and learn social roles.
- Engaging in play can enhance problem-solving abilities and cognitive functioning.

- Sociodramatic play has been shown to improve language development and social interaction skills.

Research on Play Behavior

Numerous studies have explored the different dimensions and impacts of play behavior in children.

- Research indicates that play behavior varies significantly with age, social class, and gender.
- Studies have shown that children's play preferences can reflect their cognitive and social development.
- The presence of play materials and adult interaction can influence the quality and type of play.
- Observational studies have documented developmental trends in play from infancy through preschool years.

Symbolic Play and Cognitive Development

Symbolic play is a significant indicator of cognitive maturity and language development in children.

- Children begin to engage in symbolic play around the age of two, which reflects their cognitive growth.
- The ability to use symbols in play is linked to later language skills and cognitive abilities.
- Research has shown that children with more advanced symbolic play skills tend to perform better in language tasks.
- Studies suggest that the complexity of play scenarios can enhance cognitive flexibility and creativity.

Social Interaction and Play

Play serves as a vital context for social interaction and the development of social skills among children.

- Children learn to negotiate, cooperate, and resolve conflicts through play with peers.
- Sociodramatic play has been associated with increased empathy and altruistic behaviors in children.
- The quality of peer interactions during play can influence social competence and adjustment.
- Research highlights the importance of adult involvement in facilitating positive social interactions during play.

Impact of Play on Emotional Development

Play is instrumental in the emotional development of children, helping them express and manage their feelings.

- Engaging in imaginative play allows children to explore emotions and practice emotional regulation.
- Play can serve as a coping mechanism for children dealing with stress or trauma.
- Studies have shown that children who engage in more play exhibit better emotional resilience.
- The presence of supportive adults during play can enhance emotional security and confidence in children.

The Development of Early Sociodramatic Play

DEUNK, MARJOLEIN, et al. “The Development of Early Sociodramatic Play.” *Discourse Studies*, vol. 10, no. 5, 2008, pp. 615–33. *JSTOR*, http://www.jstor.org/stable/24049394. Accessed 2 Nov. 2025.

The document examines the development and transition of early sociodramatic play in children, focusing on the interactions and cognitive processes involved in pretend play.

The Development of Early Sociodramatic Play

This article examines the transition from early pretend play to sociodramatic play in a young girl named Peggy, highlighting the developmental stages and characteristics of her play interactions.

Characteristics of Early Pretend Play

- Early pretend play begins around age 2, characterized by symbolic substitution without character roles.
- Peggy, at age 2, engages in simple pretend play, using symbolic substitution (e.g., clay as food).
- The play is structured around basic roles (giver and taker) and lacks fully developed character identities.
- The interaction is not fully layered, with limited reinterpretation of roles and settings.

Transition to Sociodramatic Play

- As Peggy ages, her pretend play evolves, losing reliance on routines and expanding in thematic complexity.
- By age 3, Peggy engages in more complex interactions, such as pretending to make phone calls with a peer.
- The play incorporates more sophisticated ideational transformations, requiring imagination rather than mere substitution.
- Peggy and her playmate begin to enact situated identities, enhancing the depth and coherence of their interactions.

Theoretical Framework of Pretend Play

- The article discusses key theories on pretend play, including Harris's four elements of pretense: symbolic substitution, causal powers, suspension of objective truth, and unfolding causal chains.

- Goffman's frame analysis and Clark's layered interaction concepts are used to explain how children interpret and engage in pretend play.
- The importance of metacommunication in establishing roles and play frames is emphasized, with older children using explicit signals to indicate pretend play.

Research Methodology and Data Collection

- The study follows Peggy over a seven-month period, recording her interactions in preschool to analyze her development in pretend play.
- Data includes 25 episodes of pretend play, with a total duration of 59 minutes, showing a significant increase in play interactions at age 2;9 compared to later ages.
- The recordings capture interactions with peers and adults, providing insights into the dynamics of her play.

Results and Findings

- At age 2, Peggy's pretend play is characterized by basic symbolic substitutions and limited role enactment.
- By age 3, her play demonstrates a shift towards more complex interactions, with the introduction of character roles and imaginative scenarios.
- The findings suggest a gradual transition from simple pretend play to more sophisticated sociodramatic play, highlighting the developmental trajectory of children's play.

Development of Pretend Play

The text discusses the progression from early pretend play to more complex sociodramatic play in children.

- Early pretend play involves simple substitutions of objects and actions without defined roles.
- Sociodramatic play includes explicit roles and identities, allowing for more complex interactions.
- Peggy's interactions demonstrate this progression from age 2:9 to 3:4, showing increased complexity in play.
- The transition involves children interpreting not only actions but also roles, places, and identities in a pretend context.

Layering in Pretend Play

The concept of layering in pretend play illustrates how children assign different meanings to elements in their play.

- Layering involves real-world meanings and pretend meanings for participants, roles, places, time, objects, and actions.
- In early play, children primarily substitute objects and actions, while in sociodramatic play, they also reinterpret roles and identities.
- Peggy's play interactions show a clear development in layering, with increasing specificity in roles and settings.
- The analysis highlights how children manage complex interactions through metacommunication as their play evolves.

Examples of Play Interactions

The text provides specific examples of Peggy's play interactions to illustrate the development of sociodramatic play.

- In the first play, "You can eat that," Peggy and Laura engage in simple pretend play without defined roles.
- In the second play, "Daddy on the phone," Peggy and Nicole take on the role of callers, showing a slight increase in complexity.
- In the third play, "Fixing the boat," Peggy and Alex adopt specific roles as Piets, demonstrating advanced symbolic substitution.
- The interactions reveal how children negotiate roles and meanings, enhancing their play experience.

Conclusions on Pretend Play Development

The text concludes with insights on the significance of pretend play in children's development.

- Early pretend play serves as a foundation for later sociodramatic play, facilitating role-taking and identity construction.
- The complexity of play increases as children learn to manage interactions and establish shared meanings.
- Understanding the transition from simple to complex play can inform educational practices and support children's social and cognitive development.
- The study emphasizes the importance of recognizing the layers of meaning in children's play for fostering their imaginative skills.

Mothers' and Fathers' Attitudes Regarding Pretend Play in the Context of Imaginary Companions and of Child Gender

Gleason, Tracy R. “Mothers’ and Fathers’ Attitudes Regarding Pretend Play in the Context of Imaginary Companions and of Child Gender.” *Merrill-Palmer Quarterly*, vol. 51, no. 4, 2005, pp. 412–36. *JSTOR*, http://www.jstor.org/stable/23096096. Accessed 22 Oct. 2025.

The document examines mothers' and fathers' attitudes toward pretend play in relation to their children's imaginary companions and gender, highlighting how these factors influence parental perceptions and behaviors.

Parents' Attitudes Toward Pretend Play

The study examines how mothers' and fathers' beliefs about pretend play are influenced by their children's imaginary companions and gender.

- Parents (73 mothers, 40 fathers) were surveyed about their children's pretend play and attitudes toward pretense.
- Results indicated that parents of children with imaginary companions rated their children's play more positively.
- Girls were perceived to engage in more pretend play than boys, with mothers viewing it more positively than fathers.
- The study highlights the relationship between parents' attitudes and children's individual differences in play.

Imaginary Companions and Their Impact

The presence of imaginary companions influences parents' perceptions and attitudes toward children's pretend play.

- Children with imaginary companions (39.5% of participants) were rated higher in pretend play involvement.
- Parents' attitudes toward imaginary companions varied, with some viewing them positively and others neutrally or negatively.
- The study suggests that having an imaginary companion may correlate with a child's inclination toward fantasy play.

Gender Differences in Children's Play

Children's gender affects the type and frequency of pretend play, influencing parents' perceptions and involvement.

- Girls were rated higher in their predilection for fantasy compared to boys by both mothers and fathers.
- Boys and girls engage in similar amounts of pretend play, but their themes differ, with girls favoring domestic roles and boys favoring adventurous themes.
- Parents are more likely to engage in pretend play with girls than with boys, reflecting gender biases in play.

Influence of Parents' Gender Roles

Mothers and fathers exhibit different attitudes and behaviors regarding their children's pretend play based on their gender roles.

- Mothers tend to engage more in pretend play and view it as beneficial for development, while fathers participate more spontaneously.
- The study found that mothers' beliefs about pretense were positively correlated with their participation, unlike fathers.
- Fathers reported more practical concerns regarding pretend play, such as setting limits compared to mothers.

Research Methodology and Participants

The study involved a diverse group of participants and utilized various methods to gather data on pretend play.

- 141 families were invited to participate, with 75 families responding, including 38 families with both parents.
- Children aged 36 to 69 months ($M = 52.91$ months) were included, with a balanced representation of genders (36 girls, 39 boys).
- Surveys were distributed to parents and teachers, and children were interviewed about their play and imaginary companions.

Key Findings and Statistical Analysis

The study's findings reveal significant differences in perceptions and attitudes based on imaginary companion status and child gender.

- Parents rated children's involvement in pretend play higher than teachers did, with mothers' ratings significantly higher than fathers'.
- Children with imaginary companions received higher scores for involvement in pretense ($M = 23.65$) compared to those without ($M = 21.82$).
- Gender differences were significant, with mothers rating girls' pretend play ($M = 23.70$) higher than boys' ($M = 21.30$).

Parents' Attitudes Toward Pretend Play

Parents' beliefs about pretend play significantly influence their children's imaginative activities and development.

- Parents rated the significance of pretend play, their role in it, and when they would redirect children away from it.
- No differences were found in composite ratings based on imaginary companion status for mothers and fathers.
- Mothers of girls had more positive attitudes toward pretend play ($M = 37.09$) compared to mothers of boys ($M = 33.55$), $p = .006$.
- Fathers showed no differences in attitudes based on child gender.
- Open-ended responses indicated that mothers who reported imaginary companions were more likely to endorse language development as a benefit of pretense (20% vs. 2.9%, $p = .026$).

Environment Provided for Pretend Play

The availability of toys and limits set by parents for pretend play varied based on child gender and imaginary companion status.

- Mothers and fathers reported providing more fantasy toys for daughters ($M = 4.66$ for mothers, $M = 5.00$ for fathers) than for sons ($M = 4.05$ for mothers, $M = 4.00$ for fathers).
- Fathers of children with imaginary companions reported placing fewer limits on pretense ($M = 0.40$) compared to those without ($M = 1.29$, $p = .007$).
- A greater proportion of mothers of children with imaginary companions (29.6%) were likely to mind pretense when guests were over compared to those without (11.6%, $p = .059$).
- Fathers of children with imaginary companions were less likely to mind pretense during family dinners (11.8% vs. 47.6%, $p = .018$).

Comparisons of Spouses' Reports

Differences in mothers' reports were noted based on whether their partners participated in the study.

- Mothers without participating partners set more limits on pretense ($M = 1.5$) than those with participating partners ($M = 0.51$, $p < .001$).
- A higher percentage of mothers whose partners did not participate reported they would mind pretense during family dinners (42.9% vs. 8.6%, $p < .01$).
- Children of mothers whose partners did not participate were significantly older ($M = 56.63$ months) than those with participating fathers ($M = 49.65$ months, $p = .001$).

Perceptions of Pretend Play by Parents

Parents' perceptions of children's pretend play were influenced by child gender and imaginary companion status.

- A repeated-measures ANOVA showed that parents rated daughters' predilection for fantasy higher ($M = 5.39$) than sons' ($M = 3.83$, $p < .001$).
- Mothers held more positive views of imaginative play ($M = 36.83$) than fathers ($M = 35.14$, $p = .03$).
- No differences emerged in the number of categories cited by mothers and fathers regarding the developmental significance of pretend play.

Relation of Imaginary Companions to Parents' Views

Parents' attitudes toward pretend play were largely unaffected by whether their children had imaginary companions.

- Parents rated children's involvement in pretense similarly regardless of imaginary companion status.
- Mothers of children with imaginary companions were more likely to associate pretend play with language development.
- Fathers who reported imaginary companions were more likely to endorse social development benefits from pretense.

Child Gender's Impact on Parents' Views

Parents rated girls' pretend play higher than boys', despite research suggesting similar levels of pretend play across genders.

- Mothers and fathers perceived daughters as more engaged in pretense than sons.
- Parents provided more fantasy-oriented toys for daughters than sons, indicating gendered perceptions of play.

- Fathers of sons were more likely to limit pretense during meals out (63.2% vs. 31.6% for daughters, $p = .05$).

Gender Differences in Parental Attitudes

Mothers exhibited more positive attitudes toward pretend play than fathers, suggesting differing roles in children's imaginative activities.

- A higher proportion of mothers expressed concerns about cognitive issues related to pretend play compared to fathers.
- Mothers reported a wider variety of conditions under which they would worry about children's pretend play.
- Fathers were more focused on the amount of pretend play rather than its content, indicating a difference in perspective.

Gender, Media, Use

Source: Calvert, Sandra L., and Barbara J. Wilson. "Make-Believe Play, Imagination, and Creativity: Links to Children's Media Exposure." *The Handbook of Children, Media, and Development /*, Wiley-Blackwell, 2008, https://doi.org/10.1002/9781444302752.

Gender socialization – Process in which children learn the norms and social expectations for males and females in their culture (Ward, 2003)

- Traditionally, children learned gender roles through observation of males and females in their families, later their friends and peers at school
- Media now provides early window on the larger worlds in front of a screen
- Their already established perception of gender may not be similar to what they consume in media

Sex and Gender in Childhood

- Between 2 and 7 years olds, most children come to understand that their bioligical sex is constant and does not change over time (Kohlberg, 1966)
- Young children begin to establish patterns, or schemas, of beliefs and behaviors typically associated with biological sex differences prevalent in their culture.
    - Use gender schemas to process and understand gender oriented behavior (Martine & Halverson, 1981) , also influence memory and problem solving

- Gender schemas lead to gender stereotypes because behavio rthat conforms to the established schema is more easily processed, understood, and remembered.
- Ex. Children with gender schema may see a female nurse and male doctor even though the video portrays otherwise (Cordua, McGraw, & Dragman, 1979)

- Gender roles is learned in three ways
    - Gendered institutions
        - Includes family, schools, workplaces, and media
        - Relect ideda that gender is present in the processes, practices, images, and ideologies, and distributions of power in various aspects of social life (Acker, 1992, p.567)
        - Family – Different roles for the father and mother
        - School – Often run by men and have different expectations based off of gender
        - Media – Reflect gendered ideology of the culture (Acker, 1992)

Gendered Media

- Representative samples of 8 to 18 year olds conducted in 1999 and 2004, have shown that gender was the main motivation behind television shows choices (Roberts & Foehr, 2004; Roberts, Foehr. & Rideout, 2005)
    - Boys preferred sports and action programs on television
    - Girls chose child and family-oriented content, romance, and comedy
    - Consistently found that males are more likely to choose male-oriented content than girls are to choose only female-oriented content

Cultural Differences in Pretend Play

Source: Haight, W. L., Wang, X., Fung, H. H., Williams, K., & Mintz, J. (1999). Universal, Developmental, and Variable Aspects of Young Children's Play: A Cross-Cultural Comparison of Pretending at Home. *Child Development*, *70*(6), 1477–1488. http://www.jstor.org/stable/1132319

Universal Dimensions of Pretend Play

- **Physical Ecology**: Objects play a crucial role in young children's pretend play, particularly toy miniatures like dolls and cars. Evidence suggests that even in cultures with fewer toys, children adapt by creating props from available materials.

- **Interpersonal Context**: Pretend play often occurs in social settings, with caregivers, siblings, and friends playing significant roles. This interaction enhances the complexity and duration of the play.
- **Social Interaction**: As children develop, they become more engaged in initiating and elaborating on pretend play episodes, indicating a shift towards greater social interaction in play.
- **Social Functions**: Pretend play serves various social functions, including teaching and guiding children towards socially acceptable behaviors, especially in caregiver-child interactions.
- **Content**: The themes of pretend play often reflect daily living activities and cultural norms, illustrating the interplay between culture and child development.

Developmental Dimensions of Pretend Play

- **Social Interaction Growth**: As children's social skills develop, they increasingly initiate pretend play and elaborate on their partner's actions, showcasing their growing communicative competencies.
- **Role of Caregivers**: Caregivers shift from primarily playful initiators to educators, using pretend play to teach socially desirable behaviors as children become more skilled in pretending.
- **Cultural Variation**: The functions of pretend play differ across cultures, with some caregivers focusing more on socialization through play than others, impacting children's understanding of social norms.
- **Encouraging Participation**: Children’s active participation tends to increase as they grow, leading to more complex and varied interactions with caregivers and peers.
- **Observational Studies**: Longitudinal studies highlight these developmental changes and the importance of social interactions in the evolution of pretend play.

Variable Dimensions of Pretend Play

- **Physical Ecology Variation**: The availability of toys and objects influences how children engage in pretend play, with cultural differences affecting the types of objects used.

- **Importance of Partners**: The choice of play partners (caregivers, siblings, friends) can significantly shape the nature of pretend play, affecting how children learn and interact.
- **Cultural Contexts**: In cultures where adults do not actively participate in children's play, children often engage in solo play or play among peers, which can limit the complexity of their interactions.
- **Adult Participation Differences**: Differences in adult participation in play between cultures can affect children's developmental trajectories in social skills and imaginative play.
- **Social Functions in Non-Western Cultures**: There is limited research on how pretend play serves social functions in non-Western communities, suggesting a need for further exploration of these dynamics.

Cultural Themes in Pretend Play

- **Cultural-Specific Themes**: Children's pretend play reflects cultural values, with themes varying significantly from one culture to another (e.g., canoeing in Marquesas Islands vs. family roles in Korean American families).
- **Socialization Goals**: Caregivers' narratives during play often emphasize different values, such as individuality in European American families versus social harmony in Chinese families.
- **Variability in Content**: The themes of caregiver-child pretend play are likely to differ based on cultural backgrounds, influencing how children perceive societal norms and routines.
- **Teaching through Play**: In some cultures, pretend play is a vehicle for teaching moral and social standards, indicating its role in cultural transmission.
- **Research Gaps**: The need for more research on how these themes manifest in diverse cultural contexts is evident, particularly in understanding the implications for child development.

Pretend Play Observations

- Children engaged in **spontaneous pretend play** at all ages studied (30, 36, and 48 months).
- **Ethnographic descriptions** revealed differences in play environments:

- Irish American children had extensive, elaborate toy collections.
- Chinese children had fewer but still significant play items.
- Observations indicated that:
- All children exhibited some form of pretend play, often involving toys.
- Social pretend play was more frequent among Chinese children, whereas Irish American children used more toy miniatures.
- The study highlighted that social interactions were a key component of pretend play, with variations across cultural contexts.
- **Social functions** of play were examined, showing differences in how caregivers interacted with children, with Irish Americans prioritizing self-esteem and Chinese caregivers focusing on moral development through play.
- **Key Findings**:
- On average, **social pretend play** was more typical in Chinese children's play, with higher engagement in pretend scenarios involving caregivers.
- Differences in the proportion of play involving other children were noted, with Irish American children participating more frequently in peer play.

Interpersonal Context and Functions of Pretend Play

- **Social Ecology**:
- Chinese families in Taipei had less extensive social networks compared to Irish American families in Chicago, impacting the nature of children's interactions.
- **Caregiver Interaction**:
- Chinese caregivers were more directive, emphasizing mature behavior, while Irish American caregivers focused on individual needs and child-led interactions.
- **Pretend Play Initiations**:
- All children initiated pretend play episodes, with Irish American children showing a greater tendency to lead these interactions.
- Responsiveness to each other’s initiations increased with age.
- **Social Functions of Caregiver-Child Pretend Play**:

- Both cultures valued pretend play, but the objectives differed:
- Irish American caregivers aimed for self-esteem development.
- Chinese caregivers used play for moral and social skill development, emphasizing **'opportunity education'**.
- The proportion of caregiver-initiated play varied in function, indicating different cultural priorities in socialization practices.

Caregiver Initiations in Pretend Play

- A study analyzed the **proportion of caregiver initiations** in pretend play across different communities and ages, revealing significant differences based on community type:
- **Significant Findings:**
- Chinese caregivers: 30 months (.51 .09) to 48 months (.30 .09).
- Irish American caregivers: 30 months (.97 .04) to 48 months (.71 .04).
- Caregiver-child interactions aimed at managing conflicts showed no significant changes, with a mean of .10 .02.
- Chinese caregivers often initiated pretend play to practice **proper conduct** (mean proportion: .38 .06) compared to Irish American caregivers (mean: .00 .00).

Content of Pretend Play by Community

- The pretend play characteristics varied significantly between **Irish American** and **Chinese caregivers**:
- **Fantasy Themes:**
- Irish American: 21% of episodes with fantasy themes (.21 .07).
- Chinese: 5% of episodes with fantasy themes (.05 .02).
- **Caretaking Themes:**
- Irish American caregivers emphasized caretaking (29% episodes; .29 .08).
- Chinese caregivers showed less focus on caretaking (7%; .07 .04).
- **Social Interactions with Non-Kin Adults:**

- Chinese caregivers had higher engagement in social interactions with non-kin adults: 30 months (50%), 36 months (74%), and 48 months (86%).
- Irish American caregivers showed significantly lower percentages (2%, 20%, and 2% respectively).